

Vietnam



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Essay

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Vietnam Essay 1

How important were the difficulties faced by American soldiers as the main reason why the USA lost the war in Vietnam?

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The Vietnam war was one of the most embarrassing losses for the USA. A supposed military superpower brought down by a small rebel group. It's a tale replicated in stories now so often it has become cliché. In this essay I will discuss the different factors which resulted in this historic defeat. These include the difficulties faced by American (US) troops, the strengths of North Vietnam (Viet Cong), the changing public opinion in America and the weaknesses of south Vietnam. I will be arguing that the strengths of North Vietnam outweigh the difficulties faced by US troops as the primary reason why the USA lost the war.

But first, let us set the scene. WW2 is over, the world is starting to rebuild, we are in the midst of the Cold War, between

America and Russia. America is on high alert to the 'Threat' of communism. Their belief is that if one country falls to Communism another will soon follow in its path, this is often referred to as Domino Theory. So, when the south Vietnam Government sent out a call for help to "Protect" them from a communist uprising – The Viet Cong – America was glad to answer that call.

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Our first factor is of course the many difficulties that US troops faced, when they set foot in Vietnam. These difficulties were significant because they reduced the effectiveness of the American forces usual tactics and directly caused lower morale in the ranks. Many of the American troops were young, inexperienced conscripts who had very little understanding of Vietnam. So, when they were suddenly thrust from the concrete jungles of America with its towering skyscrapers into the real jungles of Vietnam, they had an adverse reaction to the extremely harsh conditions; dense jungle, intense heat, unfamiliar diseases, and constant fear of ambush.

These conditions made it difficult for them to fight the Viet Cong who rarely fought the conventional battles these men had (briefly) been trained for. Instead, the Viet Cong used their intimate familiarity with the terrain to apply guerrilla tactics such as hit-and-run attacks and booby traps. A US Marine – Philip Caputo, who served in Vietnam from 1965–1966, wrote about the disorientation experienced by American troops due to these attacks in his book *A Rumor of war*:

“Without a front, flanks or rear, we fought a formless war against a formless enemy who evaporated like the morning jungle mist, only to materialise in some unexpected place.”

This primary source¹ directly illustrates how the guerrilla warfare tactics created a sense of confusion and frustration among American soldiers. The inability to identify the enemy was further emphasised by many other soldiers who later said that they could never tell who the enemy was, thus they treated everyone with suspicion and distrust. Further, they go on to describe the fear and ostracisation they felt, saying that the enemy was everywhere and everyone, and that they were “***the foreigners in their country.***”²

As a result of these tactics, US troops would often struggle to identify the enemy, which caused confusion, frustration and fear. These factors significantly impacted the soldiers' morale and combat ability. Thus, we can see that the difficulties faced by the American troops were indeed an important reason for the eventual failure because no matter how much more technologically advanced the US was, they were simply not ready for these challenges.

But on the other hand, even with these difficulties, many historians believe if not for other mitigating factors the USA would still have won the Vietnam war due to their military strength.

¹ Source Written by the time of by person whom experienced the events.

² Based on testimony from Vietnam vets, such as Thomas Giltner - US soldier

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Let us now move onto our next factor that being, the strength and determination of North Vietnam and the Viet Cong.

Their use of guerrilla tactics (as mentioned above) significantly lessened the impact that the USA's superior firepower caused. They built an extensive tunnel system to get around undetected. Their willingness to endure mass casualties and continue fighting meant that the USA could not easily make them agree to a surrender.

With the majority of reports saying that up to **1,100,000** North Vietnamese citizens and Viet Cong fighters died.

North Vietnam also benefited from powerful leadership under leaders such as Ho Chi Minh and General Giap, whose excellence in developing strategies to outlast and exhaust American troops proved pivotal in the eventual defeat and withdrawal of the USA. This shows that the enemy's strength both strategically and mentally was more important than the difficulties faced by US troops. Because it demonstrates that the Viet Cong were more willing to endure through it all because of the faith and admiration they had for their leaders and their tactics.

However, many historians dispute this interpretation saying that the Viet Cong were not effective in strength and tactics. But they argue North Vietnamese success came partly from external support (USSR/China weapons and supplies) rather than purely their own strength, thus American troops were in actuality fighting a proxy war against similar military superpowers.

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Our third factor which we now turn to is the changing public opinions in the USA. First, we need to establish that the Vietnam war is often referred to as the first TV war. With events such as the My Lai massacre (1968), the bombing of civilians and heavy US casualties, being broadcast directly into American (and other countries) homes.

Further, the US had – to ensure they had enough troops – began drafting many young men, this made the war very unpopular among these young people and many of their families.

These events led to a rise of distrust and animosity being targeted at the government as well as mass protests and riots.

The Tet Offensive of 1968 was particularly important to this change in public opinion, because although the US won militarily, it shocked the American public, convincing many that the war simply could not be won. The influential CBS news anchor Walter Cronkite, broadcast a special report on February 27, 1968, in which he stated:

“It is increasingly clear to this reporter that the only rational way out then will be to negotiate, not as victors, but as an honourable people who lived up to their pledge to defend democracy and did the best they could,”

This broadcast is widely regarded as a turning point in public opinion as it shows that to many Americans at the time the best way of getting out was to make peace and withdraw. This forced politicians to scale back US involvement and eventually begin Vietnamisation – the process to hand the fight back to south

Vietnam -. Public opinion therefore played a major role because it directly shaped the political and social decisions that led to the withdrawal from Vietnam in 1973.

However, many military historians argue public opinion only turned against the war because of military failures on the ground, meaning it was a consequence of the US losing ground rather than a cause of the defeat, which further goes to show just how important the strength of North Vietnam was as a factor.

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Our fourth factor which we must consider is the inherent weaknesses of the south Vietnamese government.

According to historian Simon Wood in his book *The Cold War 1945-1989*,

“South Vietnam was a corrupt military dictatorship”
and “Many generals were corrupt”

And this is reflected in the fact that the government had very narrow interests sparking protests from (of all people) Buddhist monks, even after the murder of President Diem, little changed about the corruption. As the next major leader Thieu simply gained power and continued to be corrupt. This inherent weakness and corruption, meant that many south Vietnamese soldiers and citizens died during the war. Further, due to their leader’s inadequacy many people in the south were sympathetic to the Viet Cong and North Vietnamese Government especially in rural areas.

This factor was important in the US losing as it caused low morale amongst those who found it difficult to fight for and support corrupt regimes and made the US troops and citizens question why they were supporting the corrupt south in this war.

On the other hand, this factor can be argued to be less important because the South Vietnamese government forced peasants to live in Strategic Hamlets, this programme meant that it was harder for the Viet Cong to fight and hide so weaknesses of South Vietnam should not be considered the most important reason for the US losing.

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In conclusion, though the difficulties faced by the American troops was indeed an important factor in why the USA ultimately lost the Vietnam war, as they limited the army's combat effectiveness and morale. However other factors such as changing public opinion and the weakness and corruption of south Vietnam, I believe are more influential in America's defeat and withdrawal from Vietnam.

However, in my opinion the most important factor when discussing why America lost the war is the strength, determination and strategic brilliance of the Viet Cong. Combined with the collapsing support from the US public, these factors played a much larger role in shaping America's eventual defeat and withdrawal than the difficulties faced by US troops.

Further, the difficulties faced by US troops would not have been so potent without the guerrilla tactics of the Viet Cong –

Without the Viet Cong using their enemy's unfamiliarity with the jungles against them the US troops would have won due to sheer firepower.

Ultimately, I believe the USA failed because it underestimated its enemy, could not win support of the Vietnamese people nor maintain a public and political backing for such a long and costly war.

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